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Review

Reviewed Work(s): *The Fall of the Romanovs: Political Dreams and Personal Struggles in a Time of Revolution* by Mark D. Steinberg and Vladimir M. Khrustalev; *The Romanovs: The Final Chapter* by Robert K. Massie; *Tsar: The Lost World of Nicholas and Alexandra* by Peter Kurth

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- Mark D. Steinberg and Vladimir M. Khrustalev. *The Fall of the Romanovs: Political Dreams and Personal Struggles in a Time of Revolution*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1995. 444 pp. \$27.50.
- Robert K. Massie. *The Romanovs: The Final Chapter*. New York: Random House, 1995. 308 pp. \$25.00.
- Peter Kurth. *Tsar: The Lost World of Nicholas and Alexandra*. Boston: Little, Brown and Co., 1995. 229 pp. \$60.00.

There has always been a lively popular interest in Nicholas, primarily due to the mystery surrounding the family's murder and the persistent rumors that one or more of them survived. And with the disclosure of the family's burial place and the macabre details of identification of the bodies, the Romanovs have become the object of considerable media attention once again. While few mourned at the time of their deaths, in retrospect the killing of the Romanovs has acquired an air of great tragedy. The horror and misery unleashed on the Russian people by the Bolsheviks have made the last emperor look benevolent and benign by comparison, and he has taken on the mantle of martyr. In a broader sense some have come to look on the last Romanovs as symbols of a civilization destroyed in the fires of the First World War, with the Russian imperial family as the first victims of a new age of ideological totalitarianism and brutality.

The collapse of Communist rule in the former Soviet Union ushered in a new era in the study of Russian and Soviet history. Archival material that was previously unavailable to scholars is now accessible. This allows for more exact and detailed study of problems and periods as well as new interpretations. One subject which has been the beneficiary of newly available archival material is Nicholas II and his family. In recent years there has been a spate of books on Nicholas, but their quality and value has been very uneven. There is a tendency to dwell on the tragic and mysterious. Three recent volumes available in English, Marc Ferro's *Nicholas II* (1990/93), Edvard Radzinsky's *The Last Emperor* (1993), and Dominic Lieven's *Nicholas II* (1993) are good examples of this. Ferro and Radzinsky concentrate on Nicholas as a flawed historical character doomed to a miserable fate. Ferro in the end tries to make the case that only Nicholas and Aleksei were executed while the rest of the family somehow made their way to Western Europe to live in obscurity, except of course for the notorious Anna Anderson/Anastasia. Ferro's thesis was subsequently discredited by the evidence of the mass grave outside Ekaterinburg and the genetic testing performed on tissue belonging to Anna Anderson. Radzinsky's later book does not make Ferro's mistake, but as a playwright Radzinsky tends to the dramatic and fanciful. Only Lieven's work, with its focus on politics, presents a balanced and thoughtful approach. These books are now joined by three new works on the last tsar—a monograph based on archival sources by Steinberg and Khrustalev and books by Massie and Kurth that are aimed at a more general readership.

The Yale Annals of Communism series was designed to make use of newly available documents from former Soviet archives to shed new light on important issues and events in recent Russian and Soviet history. The Fall of the Romanovs chronicles the months from the February revolution to July 1918, examining the circumstances of the collapse of the autocracy, the situation of the tsar's family in their subsequent imprisonment, and their ultimate execution and secret burial. The focus here is relatively narrow, primarily on the tsar and his family and those who came into immediate contact with them. The means of the examination are documents, many previously unavailable, from the former Soviet archival holdings of Nicholas II, Alexandra, other members of the imperial family, and those of the Provisional Government, the All-Russian Central Executive Committee, the Council of People's Commissars, and other Russian and Soviet state agencies. The purpose of the book is to provide an immediate portrait of this tumultuous period as seen through the eyes of participants who then recorded their impressions in the included documents. The picture that emerges is often chaotic, sometimes inherently contradictory, and sometimes emerging with stunning clarity. But this is in the nature of endeavoring to recapture the past with any accuracy.

The book is divided into four chapters with an introduction. The introduction and the narrative section of each chapter are the work of Mark D. Steinberg. Vladimir Khrustalev's contribution is the selection of documents from former Soviet archives, which form the backbone of the book. In addition, the book contains several useful maps, reproductions of a number of the original texts, a selection of photographs, a glossary of names and institutions, a chronology of events, a short bibliography, and a listing of the provenance of all the documents.

In his introduction Steinberg argues for a modified reading of the essential world view of Nicholas and Alexandra. Rather than the popular image of a feckless and naive would-be autocrat and his hysterical harpy wife, Steinberg stresses the deep religious convictions of the royal couple. This religiosity instilled in Nicholas the belief in his role as a divinely sanctioned ruler and a fatalism based on the conviction that his fate and that of Russia were in God's hands; any attempt to overrule God's judgments, on his part or that of others, was of course futile. For Alexandra's part she shared Nicholas' belief that God was shaping their own and Russia's destinies. Aleksei's hemophilia and the revolution were both trials imposed due to their or others' sinfulness; Rasputin was a divinely-provided instrument to relieve the first, while the Romanovs waited in vain for relief from the second. It was this religious and anachronistic vision of the Russian autocracy, Steinberg argues, which set the Romanovs on a collision course with the currents of political and social change in their rapidly evolving state.

The book's four chapters are divided chronologically into the events surrounding the February revolution and Nicholas' abdication; the family's subsequent incarceration at Tsarskoe selo through July 1917; their transfer to Tobolsk, where they were held until Nicholas, Alexandra, and Maria were removed to Ekaterinburg

in April 1918, with the rest of the family following in May; and the family's final months in Ekaterinburg and ultimate execution. Each chapter begins with a narrative section that chronicles the events that occurred during the period the chapter covers, as well as some analysis of those events and of the documents that have been chosen to represent the views and reactions of the actors. There follows the documents themselves (those in Russian translated by Elizabeth Tucker).

It is the authors' stated purpose not to provide new interpretation of the last Romanovs (although a partial attempt at this is made in the introduction), but to provide the reader with the raw material—the newly available archival material—that will allow the reader to exercise his/her own judgment and interpretive skills. Vladimir Khrustalev has done an admirable job of selecting archival materials that provide a vivid and immediate impression of the thoughts, outlook, and beliefs of the people involved in these tumultuous and eventually tragic events that overtook Russia in 1917. In the first chapter we find letters between Nicholas and Alexandra from February 1917, entries from Nicholas' diary, desperate pleas from the Duma, the generals, and Nicholas' own family to take some decisive action to save his regime, the abdication manifesto, and the order of the Petrograd soviet to arrest the Romanovs. While Steinberg in his introduction argues for a modified view of Nicholas and Alexandra, emphasizing their deep religious beliefs, the letters, telegrams, and diary entries serve to reinforce the long-held view of Nicholas and his wife as a devoted couple and parents who were nevertheless completely unequipped to be leaders of a great state undergoing tremendous strife and upheaval. While their religious fatalism is clearly evident, so is their blinkered inability to see and interpret events as they unfolded and the mood and needs of the country they ruled.

While Nicholas abdicated with little resistance, having the imperial family in captivity proved to be a more vexing political problem, which the subsequent three chapters chronicle. Kerensky was determined that the former rulers be treated humanely, that the revolution could be magnanimous in its success. However, radicalized elements called for their imprisonment and trial. The Romanovs, under house arrest at Tsarskoe selo, saw their treatment vary according to which element held sway at the moment. This is documented by declarations by various soviets and soldiers' organizations and reflected in Nicholas' diary.

After attempts to have the family evacuated to England collapsed, Kerenskii was forced to move them to the Ural town of Tobolsk following the abortive July uprising in Petrograd. Here the conditions of imprisonment gradually became more restrictive. By late spring 1918 the Romanovs became the epicenter of competing factions that wished to determine their fate, including White rescuers and various Bolshevik strongholds in the Ural region that wished to assert their revolutionary zeal and make an example of the family. Rumors printed in the press that the family had escaped or been rescued exacerbated the situation. Finally, the Ekaterinburg soviet, either acting on its own or with Moscow's approval—the

record is still unclear on this point—asserted itself and had the family transferred to the "house of special purpose" there.

With the transfer to Ekaterinburg, events were set into motion that decided the fate of the Romanovs. The Soviet government in Moscow had decided to put Nicholas on trial for crimes against the Russian people or, if the press of events made it more expedient, to have him executed without trial to prevent his falling into the hands of the White army that was pressing towards the Urals. Evidently Nicholas himself recognized that his situation had become perilous. According to one of his guards, he remarked he would go anywhere, "only not to the Urals." The final act began on July 4, 1918, when responsibility for guarding the Ipatiev house was assumed by Iakov Iurovskii, a Chekist who organized the execution squad on July 16. The final chapter ends with two separate accounts by Iurovskii of his part in the execution and disposal of the bodies.

Although it has become common wisdom that the execution of the Romanovs was ordered by Moscow (and even by Lenin personally in some accounts), Steinberg and Khrustalev are careful to point out that the opening of the archives has not provided any evidence to support this claim. Though testimony of a telegram sent by Lenin to Ekaterinburg has appeared, the actual telegram has not. And in Iurovskii's account he says that the telegram authorizing the execution came from Perm (presumably from members of the Ekaterinburg soviet), not from Moscow. While it is very likely that Moscow ordered the deaths of the Romanovs, this question remains open.

Massie's book is the sequel to his very popular *Nicholas and Alexandra*, prompted by the discovery of the remains of the royal family and the efforts to verify scientifically that these remains are indeed the bones of the Romanovs. The first part of the book—twelve chapters—is devoted to describing how the grave was discovered, the rather chaotic efforts by various competing Russian government bodies and teams of Western scientists to establish first claim on the bones and their identification, and the methods used to establish the identity of individuals found in the mass grave. This is the most interesting and useful part of Massie's book.

As far as serious historical inquiry is concerned, Massie leaves this behind in the subsequent portions of the book. The next section—six chapters—revolves primarily around the rather bizarre legal battle over a section of intestine left behind by the woman who called herself Anna Anderson and who claimed to be Grand Duchess Anastasia. When the right to control this bit of tissue was finally resolved and it was subjected to DNA testing, the results proved that not only could Anna Anderson not have been a Romanov, but also that she was indeed Franziska Schanzkowska, as an investigator for members of the Romanov family had concluded back in the 1920s. This should have settled the matter once and for all, but those who supported her claim, including the author of the third book under review, refused to accept the findings, preferring their beliefs to factual ev-

idence. The final two sections of the book—one chapter apiece—concern respectively the squabbles among the survivors of the Romanov family over which one was the rightful heir to the Russian throne and a brief account of Nicholas and his family's final days in the Ipatiev house in Ekaterinburg.

Massie's book is essentially journalistic in nature, based on his first-hand observation of much of the action described and interviews with the participants. With his journalist's instincts, Massie tends to focus on the dramatic and entertaining aspects of the story, an approach that seriously flawed his earlier work on Nicholas and Alexandra, in which he sought to hinge the fall of the dynasty on Aleksei's hemophilia and the presence of Rasputin.

Tsar: The Lost World of Nicholas and Alexandra is a handsome coffee-table-sized book of photographs of the last Romanovs and their world, supplemented by current color photographs of the sites associated with them. The text accompanying the photography is by Peter Kurth, author of *Anastasia: The Riddle of Anna Anderson*. Kurth's narrative is reasonably accurate and reliable when he sticks to the facts, but his interpretation of the last ruling family of Russia is overly sentimental and romantic, closely resembling Massie's *Nicholas and Alexandra*. Kurth almost completely ignores what an irresponsible and weak ruler Nicholas was. The text descends into bathos while describing the captivity of the Romanovs after Nicholas' abdication, calling their final days in Ekaterinburg "a living hell." While the family must surely have been traumatized by their treatment by Bolshevik guards and their deaths were unarguably horrible, their experience in captivity was relatively mild compared with what other Russians were receiving at the hands of the new regime.

As noted above, Kurth, as one of the supporters of Anna Anderson's claim to be Anastasia, refuses to let the matter lie settled. As Massie quotes him in his book, on being informed of the results of the DNA testing, Kurth states, "For me—just because of some tests—I cannot one day say, 'Oh, well, I was wrong.' It isn't that simple." In his own book Kurth cites photographic comparisons made of Anderson and Anastasia's face and ears, which claimed the two matched (these tests he is willing to accept), to oppose the DNA results, rather like comparing Bertillon measurements against fingerprint evidence. He further argues that all those who met Anderson took her for a lady, which rendered it impossible that she had been raised in a Polish peasant hut. This is more a tribute to the prejudices and snobbery of these people than Anderson's real identity and origins.

It should be noted, however, that the remains of Aleksei and Anastasia (according to the American experts) have not been recovered. Iurovskii's explanation for why two bodies were burned while the others were buried are unconvincing, and according to forensic experts the bodies could not possibly have been completely destroyed in this manner. This unresolved mystery will continue to lend an air of myth and mystery to the fate of the imperial family. The deaths of the Romanovs is just one chapter in Russian and Soviet history which has become

more clear due to the newly available contents of Soviet archives and the advances of modern science brought to bear on historical questions. The monograph by Steinberg and Khrustalev, soberly analyzing documentary evidence, goes a long way toward dispelling a number of myths that have grown up around the imperial family and their fate. Unfortunately, it will probably not achieve as wide an audience as the other two works.

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Albert Glotzer. *Trotsky: Memoir & Critique*. Buffalo, NY: Prometheus Books, n. d. [1989]. 343 pp. \$30.95.

Albert Glotzer is a life-long Social Democrat who played an important role in the American Trotskyist movement, particularly between the foundation of the Communist League of America in 1929 and the creation of the Independent Socialist League in April 1940. The book under review mixes reminiscences of Trotsky with retrospective criticism of Trotsky's political program. As memoir the book is necessarily episodic: we have a sharply drawn portrait of Trotsky's life in Kadikoy, Turkey, during the first period of his exile from the USSR; a sketch occasioned by Glotzer's interactions with Trotsky before and after the 1934 international youth conference in Paris; and a full, lively and sympathetic account of Trotsky's 1937 testimony in Mexico City before the Dewey Commission concerning the ongoing Stalinist show trials. Glotzer presents Trotsky as an energetic, intellectually curious but dogmatic figure, a man who was demanding of himself and abrupt or imperious to his sympathizers, a politician who was blessed with high orders of prophetic insight (Glotzer thinks Trotsky foresaw the Holocaust), yet could be wildly and tragically mistaken in his political prognostications (witness his misreading of Stalin). If, on the one hand, Glotzer considers Trotsky a "monumental partner" of Lenin in the making of the Russian Revolution and the Soviet state, he also acknowledges, on the other hand, that Trotsky must bear some responsibility for the disasters of Stalinism. He criticizes Trotsky for embracing centralism after 1917, for imagining against the evidence that the Soviet Union in the 1930s was still a "workers' state," and, above all, for failing to defend the democratic component of socialism. In the course of criticizing Trotsky, Glotzer casts a damning eye on the Stalinists and bureaucratic centralists who dominated the American Left during the 1930s. Incidentally, Glotzer is honest enough to fault himself for adhering to the "traditional Leninist view" forty years ago, although he says in mitigation that "I emphasized the democratic side of organizational life" (289).

Glotzer's book will be useful to students of Trotskyism, especially in the American context. It may also be instructive to those historians interested in under-